Question 2 Prose: How To Get Full Marks

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How To Get Full Marks

The starting point for the analysis of any text is active reading. This means, as you read, annotating the text with your own comments and questions. Texts will often contain many layers of meaning, so it is important that you explore beyond any surface meanings to uncover the deeper ideas and themes. In the Unseen paper, you won't necessarily be able to write about the background or historical context of the extract, so it is even more important to concentrate on what the text is telling you. There may be, however, some helpful information in the question, such as whether the extract is taken from the start or the end of a text, which will help you to place it in context.

It is tempting to jump straight in and start writing immediately. However, following this guide will ensure you answer the question in the way the examiners are looking for.

Below you will find sections on:

- What skills are required
- Steps for success
- Top tips

What skills are required

Both question options in this exam paper assess all four assessment objectives equally. This means it is important that you know what skills these assessment objectives require you to demonstrate in order to get the most marks.

- **AO1** is about demonstrating detailed knowledge of the text:
  - This can be through reference to specific quotations and indirect references to the text
  - Whatever references you make, they need to be well-selected and well-integrated into your response
- **AO2** is about going beyond the text's surface meaning and plot to look for underlying ideas and attitudes – the writer's and your own:

Stuck on something?

Ask questions and get help with exactly what you're revising.

Got it

inform your personal response, but only if relevant to the focus of the question

- **AO3** requires **critical engagement** and evaluation of how the text works:
  - "Meanings and effects" suggests that there is more than one meaning for a text, and the language, structure and form of the text contribute to those meanings
  - It does not mean just listing the literary techniques the writer has used
  - In prose, this also means considering how the writer has presented settings, characters and events

- **AO4** refers to the way you shape your writing in order to communicate your engagement with the text:
  - These responses directly address the words in the question, which are designed to elicit personal responses, such as "powerful", "vivid", "striking", "memorable" and "moving"
  - Contextual information should help reinforce your own interpretation, but not replace it
  - Your own response is valid as long as it is supported by evidence

The following sections explore the skills you will need to demonstrate in more detail:

- Analysing prose
- Developing a personal response

Analysing prose

Question 2 on this exam paper will give you some contextual information about the passage that is printed, but primarily you are being tested on your ability to apply the skills you have developed to analyse prose (while studying Paper 1 of your IGCSE) to an unseen prose extract.

Analysing a piece of prose involves not just looking at the language the writer has used. You might also wish to consider the following techniques, all related to the form of the text:

Technique	Explanation
Plot structure	A plot could be cyclical: • This means there could be a recurrent theme or motif • Or it could mean that the plot "circles back" to the beginning The writer might also use parallelism: • This means the use of matching sentences, phrases or longer marks to balance ideas of equal importance
Mood	Mood describes the feelings or attitudes of roles and/or characters:

Help me understand

Juxtaposition	To place two things side by side to compare or contrast for effect: • This might include the use of foil characters • A foil is a character who contrasts with another character • For example, Harry Potter and Voldemort are foils
Foreshadowing	This is a warning or a prediction of a future event in the story: • The writer might also employ dramatic irony, where the reader might be aware of what is coming, but the characters are not
In medias res	This is when the story starts in the middle of the action
Flashbacks	A scene set in a time earlier than the main story: • This device can be used to convey extra information about plot or character
Soliloquies/dialogue	A soliloquy is a speech that a character makes to themselves: • It is a device in which a character's inner thoughts can be made known to the reader • Dialogue is a conversation between two or more characters in a novel or play

What to do when analysing the author's methods

- Take a whole-text approach:
  - Consider how the passage given on the exam paper might relate to the rest of the text (if you are given this information)

- Always frame your essay with the author in mind:
  - As the examiners say: "writers use methods, including language and structure, to form and express their ideas – the choices the writer makes are conscious and deliberate"
  - Therefore, write that the author "highlights X", "suggests Y", "challenges Z"
  - Use the words "so" and "because" to push you to explain your own ideas further

- Zoom out to big ideas in your analysis:
- Go from analysing language, or other writer's choices, to the author's overall intention or message

- Do not just "spot techniques":
  - Examiners dislike it when students use overly sophisticated terminology unnecessarily and without analysis
  - Knowing the names of sophisticated techniques will not gain you any more marks, especially if these techniques are only "spotted" and the author's intentions for this language are not explained
  - Instead of technique spotting, focus your analysis on the **reasons** why the author is presenting the character or theme the way they are

- Do not just limit your analysis to a close reading of the author's use of language:
  - You gain marks for explaining all of the author's choices, not just their language
  - Instead, take a whole-passage approach and think about the author's decisions about:
    - Form
    - Structure
    - Characterisation
    - Setting

- Never retell the story:
  - "Narrative" and "descriptive" answers get the lowest marks
  - Move from **what** the author is presenting to **how** and **why** they have made the choices they have

Perspective

The narrative perspective of a piece of prose is the point of view from which the story is told. It is like a lens through which we view characters and events; we interpret those characters and events based on what the speaker shows and tells us.

There are two main types of narrative perspective:

First-person narrator	• This means the story is told from the perspective of a character, most likely the protagonist • It is easily identifiable by the use of the word "I" • In a first-person narrative, the reader only has access to the experiences and thoughts of the narrator, and we see and experience events through their eyes • This can lead to the reader feeling sympathy for the character, or exposing the character as an unreliable narrator • Sometimes, the reader may know something the narrator does not seem to – this is called **dramatic irony**
Third-person narrator	• This means the story is told from a perspective that sits outside of the world of the story • The narrator refers to all of the characters by their names or pronouns • A third-person narrator is sometimes referred to as an **omniscient** narrator,

When considering the narrative perspective, ask yourself if the perspective shifts, or how the perspective affects your understanding of the extract.

Characterisation

It is important to remember that characters are constructs, not real people. You should therefore consider what each character's function is in the extract, how they are presented, how they develop and how they interact with each other. Some characters may also be "foil" characters – this means any two characters who are opposites of each other. For example, Harry Potter and Voldemort are foils of each other – they embody the idea of good versus evil. Foil characters therefore help establish important themes.

There are two main types of characterisation:

Direct characterisation	• This means what we are told by the author about a character's appearance and personality • It might also involve the writer explicitly showing what characters think of one another • For example, a character might directly describe another character's traits
Indirect characterisation	• This involves implying what a character is like • This could involve what a character says, how they say it or how they interact with other characters • It might also involve their inner thoughts and feelings, and more subtle indications of character, such as how they move and behave

Often, characters are symbolic of broader ideas or attitudes. It is therefore important to consider what a character might represent.

Structure

When considering structure in an unseen extract, you should think about:

- The way the writer has put the extract together
- How they set up the "world" being conveyed
- How they introduce characters
- What conflicts there are and how they are resolved
- How things change in the passage

Developing a personal response

A personal response is your opinion about the text, as relevant to the focus of the question. You are being asked to consider what the writer has tried to do and whether you think they have succeeded. However, it is important that your arguments are convincing, which means that they need to be supported with

How to structure your response:

Start with an introduction that demonstrates that you understand the focus of the question and the extract	You can do this by using the wording of the question to develop a **thesis** statement: • For example: "Orwell strikingly portrays the absolute power of the Party by presenting us with a society in which everything, even a person's thoughts, is monitored and controlled."
Then, structure your response into paragraphs	• Each paragraph should start with a topic sentence • You should integrate direct quotations or specific references to the text to prove your point • Then comment on **how** this evidence proves your point • Each point you make must be directly relevant to the focus of the question • Ensure you use the whole of the passage
Finish with a conclusion	• Summarise your findings and your response to these findings • Do not just repeat the points you have already made • For example: "So overall, Orwell's dystopian novel powerfully presents the absolute power of the Party by presenting us with a suffocating, bleak vision of the future as a warning against one person or organisation being able to hold complete authority over a society."

Steps for success

Following these steps will give you a strategy for answering the prose question effectively:

1. Grab your highlighter and **read the question first**:
   - Read any contextual information
   - Highlight the focus of the question
   - Highlight the focus of each of the three bullet points (these will help you to structure your answer)
2. Read the passage with the focus of the question in mind:
   - Highlight and annotate as you read

the focus of the question?
    - Do not just write a list of techniques the writer has used
3. Do a brief plan of 4–5 points, linking to the quotations you are going to use
4. Start your answer using the wording of the question:
    - This demonstrates to the examiner that you have understood both the question and the text

5. Go into detail:
    - Now you need to make as many points as possible, ranging throughout the passage
    - It is a good idea to make your points in chronological order, if possible
    - Use the annotations you have made in the margins to form the basis of each point:
        - Make your point, then support it with quotations and/or direct references to the text
        - Explain how the quote highlights the idea in the question
        - Analyse what the key words and phrases in the quotation make the reader feel about the idea in the question

    - Comment on and analyse language, form and structure
    - Link your ideas to the theme and the focus of the question:
        - You should refer back to the keyword(s) in the question throughout your answer
        - Use "because" or "as" to support your ideas with detailed reasons

    - Explore the writer's intention and message

6. Sum up:
    - Finish your answer with a "So overall…" statement
    - Zoom back out to the big ideas in the text
    - Your finishing statement should sum up what you have discovered, relevant to the focus of the question:
        - However, it should not just repeat the points you have already made

Top tips

- Avoid being too general or vague in your introduction:
    - Your introduction should address the assessment objectives in some way

- Avoid simply "re-telling" the story
- Make sure every paragraph answers the question:
    - Do not just write everything you know about the text

- Avoid unnecessary words
- Re-read each of the paragraphs you have written before you write the next:
    - Check that each paragraph is clear and that it answers the question

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